

The Answer: Innovate



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LAST MONTH, IN this space, we talked about software costs being higher than that of the hardware on which it runs. The question that arose was, “Why have freeware and open source operating systems not found mass acceptance?”

The first problem is ignorance—people just do not know that options exist. People acquire tech knowledge mostly from friends and local system assemblers, many of whom know nothing about software. The billions that the bigger paid-software companies spend on advertising gives dividends: most of us have not heard of anything but Windows, Nero, Photoshop, MS Office, Norton AntiVirus and the like.

The next hurdle the free software movement faces is compatibility. With all the hundreds of Linux flavours available, the PC hardware incompatibilities of yore might have been minimised. But we now have a whole new generation of devices—mobile phones, digital cameras, thumb drives or PDAs—that should ideally work seamlessly with our freeware enabled PCs.

This isn't happening.

Why? Because the very nature of the free software movement defies

governance! There are no procedures followed, no set team of developers, no deadlines, and no onus on developers and absolutely limited set of documentation, if at all—all of which leads to no standards.

Can this be changed? Perhaps! Recent trends have shown that even small open source projects are becoming planned affairs. Out of chaos can emerge order!

The third and perhaps the biggest challenge is to break the shackles of familiarity that paid software has imposed upon its users. Skill-sets and careers have been built upon users' existing knowledge, and asking them to forget it all and start over is a little unrealistic. In a way, a little ambitious too. Though its fans have been screaming for years about how Linux is just as easy to use as Windows, the fact is that it's different, and change is always tough.

Some free software projects have tried to clone the usability and interfaces of their paid counterparts to minimise the cold-turkey feeling users get when switching. Some even went as far as naming their products similarly (remember Lindows?), but this is not where the answer lies: often, users will love free clones of their favourite software—only until they stumble upon a difference or limitation. What follows generally involves some uninstalling!

The imagination and creativity of freeware developers seems to be restrained by a lack of vision and the lowly goals they set for themselves. They're always benchmarking their products with the best paid-software available. And they never seem to go beyond existing standards to create something better.

What freeware developers actually need to do is innovate to build better software that offers more features, more power, and gets the job done faster. As soon as they do this, the world will lap it up.